

On being named the greenest Chief Minister: Under Chamling, Sikkim has initiated a series of developmental projects, including massive plantation and regeneration of forests for which the chief minister was voted and named as the "Greenest Chief Minister of India" on the basis of rigorous survey across the Country conducted by *Down To Earth* magazine in 1999.

Under Chamling, Sikkim became the first state to ban plastic. "We were one of the first State governments to ban the use of polythene bags. We have also banned the cutting of healthy trees. Grazing is not allowed in forest areas. Endangered species are being looked after. We are also moving towards eco-tourism. These initiatives ensure that the environment remains a top priority of the State government."

Sikkim has also introduced the joint forest management-cum-integrated watershed management programme, with the government involving the common people in a big way. The common people are thus made part of the planning process, which helps greatly in successful implementation of the schemes.

A number of new forests -- Smriti Vans -- are being raised all over the state with the active participation of the people. Mr Chamling said, "Every gram panchayat has already created a Smriti Van and such forests have already come up in four district headquarters."

"We are following a green development agenda. All the development work being carried on in the State is done with an eye on the environment. We take up only projects that are environment-friendly. A large percentage of the forest area of India lies in Sikkim. We want to protect this area. To do this, I have to take some difficult decisions."

On Sikkim's remarkable performance in the health sector: Mr Chamling received the 4th JRD Tata Memorial award for Sikkim for its remarkable performance in the health sector. The state bagged this award for its achievements on such key indicators as literacy rate, child-sex ratio, full immunisation, safe delivery, Plan expenditure on social sector, percentage of women married below the age of 18, total fertility rate, infant mortality rate, female youth literacy rate, school attendance rate for girls and safe child delivery.

A jubilant Chamling, while hailing his state's achievement, said at a press conference in the capital later in the day that the award was given based on Sikkim's performance in 14 key sectors.

"The state has achieved full immunization, an indication that health sector and the issue of providing quality health care to people occupies the central theme in all discussions of the state government," Chamling said.

He further added that besides providing good health care infrastructure, the state government has also been striving to increase awareness amongst the common man on issues like harmful effects of tobacco (the state has banned the sale of gutka [chewing tobacco] and other tobacco products), cleanliness and hygiene and the government has already banned smoking in public places.

The three time chief minister added that other states have a lot to learn from Sikkim. "For instance, despite being a border state - Sikkim shares its borders with China, Nepal and Bhutan, it is very peaceful. It simply defies the mind set that all border or north eastern states are victims of insurgency. Other states have a lot to learn from Sikkim," Chamling said.



"My dream is to transform Sikkim into a prosperous, progressive, and self reliant state and I wish my people to live a full life with freedom, dignity, self-respect and righteousness"

Shri. Pawan Chamling, Chief Minister of Sikkim receiving The Nirmal Gram Puraskar Award 2009 from Hon'ble President of India